THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Level 0

Ten rooms: sitting and hands, the keyboard, fingering, the staff, the beat, notes and rests one at a time, loud and soft. Read each room, listen to it in the app, then practise.

THE ROOMS

1 · Posture and hand shape
2 · The keyboard
3 · Fingering
4 · The staff and the clefs
5 · Pulse, tempo and the bar
6 · Notes: the crotchet
7 · Notes: the minim
8 · Notes: three beats
9 · Notes: the semibreve
10 · Loud and soft

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 1

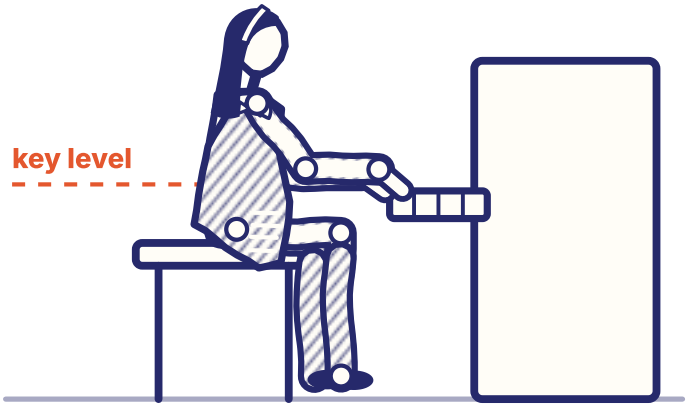
Posture and hand shape

Handbook pp. 18–20 · listen in the app: Room 1

How you sit and how you hold your hands decide how easy everything else will be. Set them up before the first note, check them every time you sit down, and they soon look after themselves.

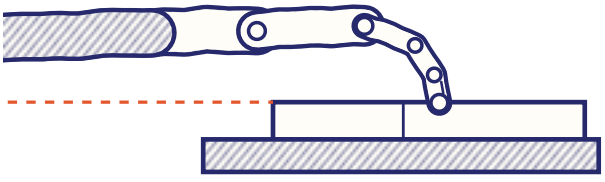
THE SECRET

Sit tall, forearms level with the keys, a round hand on the fingertips: then let the arm's weight do the work.



1. **forearms level with the keys**
   wrist neither dropped nor lifted
2. **elbows a little in front of you**
   not pinned to your sides
3. **sit on the front half of the stool**
   opposite Middle C
4. **feet flat on the floor**
   the right foot near the pedal
5. **back tall, shoulders loose**
   lean a little towards the keys

Tall back, level arms, flat feet



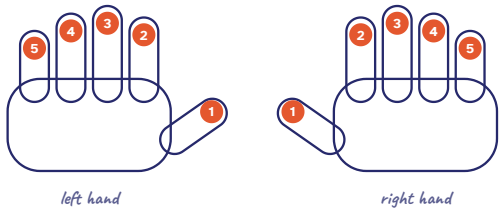
knuckles up like a bridge, the wrist level, the sound from the **fingertip**



the shape a hand makes resting on a ball

PART OF THE HAND	WHAT IT DOES
fingertips	play the keys, just behind the nail (keep nails short)
knuckles	stay up, like a bridge: they never sink in
thumb	plays on the side of its tip, relaxed, not stretched out
wrist	level with the hand, loose, never resting on the wood

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 1 · CONTINUED



Every finger has a number, **the same in both hands**: the thumb is **1**, then 2, 3, 4, and the little finger is **5**. Music often prints these numbers above or below the notes.

More on choosing fingers: Fingering p. 163.



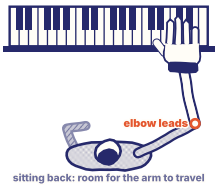
1 · Rag doll

Flop forward, arms hanging heavy. Shake them loose. Float the hands up onto the keys.



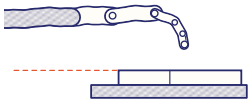
2 · Elbow wings

Elbows free, not stuck to your body. Float them out like wings, then back.



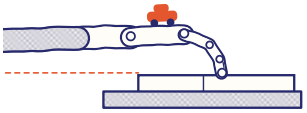
3 · Arm glide

Skate the whole arm along the keys. The round hand rides to the next group of keys.



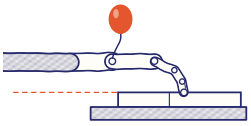
4 · Arm drop

Lift the whole arm and let it drop into a key on finger 3: firm tip, soft wrist, a round sound.



5 · Knuckle bridge

Your knuckles are a bridge a little car can drive over. Press one key slowly and hold for 3.

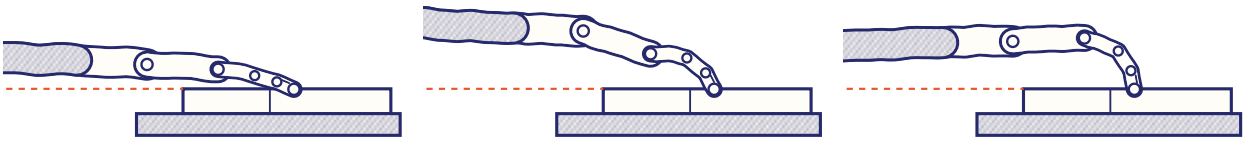


6 · Wrist balloon

As the key goes down, a balloon lifts the wrist back up to level. The fingertip stays on the key.

EXAMPLE 1

Which hand is round?



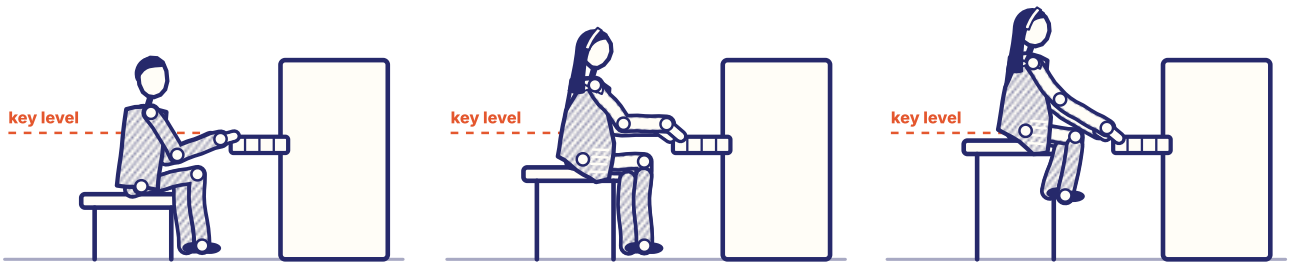
1. **Look at the knuckles:** up, or sunk in?
2. **Look at the tips:** does the finger stand on its tip?
3. **Which hand** could play all day?

C: knuckles up, curved fingers, standing on the tips. A is flat; B's knuckle has caved in.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Is the stool right?



A B C

1. **Follow the forearm** from the elbow to the keys.
2. **Uphill or downhill?** Then the stool is too low or too high.
3. **Which one** is level?

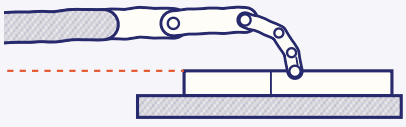
B: the forearm is level. In A the stool is too low (raise it, or add a cushion); in C it is too high.

HOW TO

The 30-second check, every time you sit down

1. **Stool:** forearms level with the keys, opposite Middle C.
2. **Body:** front half of the stool, feet flat, back tall.
3. **Shoulders:** lift them, then let them drop.
4. **Hands:** a soft ball under each palm, knuckles up.
5. **Breathe out**, then play.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



The ball test.

Hold a small ball or an orange, then put the hand on the keys without changing its shape. That is your playing hand.

TRAP

- × Wrists that sink below the keys, or rest on the wood: keep them level and loose.
- × Shoulders creeping up to the ears: let them drop between pieces.
- × Flat fingers, or a knuckle that caves in: stand on the fingertips.
- × Sitting too close, elbows squashed against your body: move the stool back a little.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 1 · CONTINUED

Practise

1 Finger numbers

★☆☆

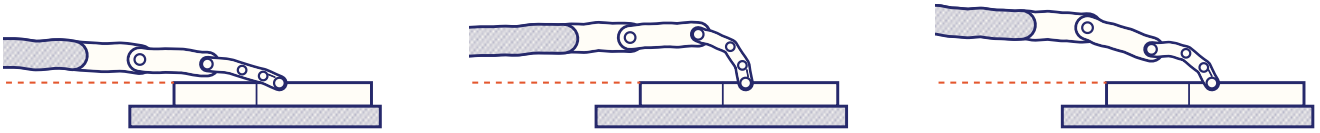
Write the number of each finger. They are the same in both hands. The first is done.

FINGER	NUMBER	FINGER	NUMBER
thumb	1	ring finger	
index finger		little finger	
middle finger			

2 Which hand is round?

★☆☆

Circle the round hand.



A B C

3 Too low, too high, or right?

★★☆

Write too low, too high or right.

WHAT YOU SEE	THE STOOL IS
The elbows are well below the keys; the forearms go uphill.	too low
The forearms are level with the keys.	
The elbows are above the keys; the wrists drop down to them.	

4 The 30-second check

★☆☆

Every time you sit down to practise, check each line and tick a circle. One circle per day.

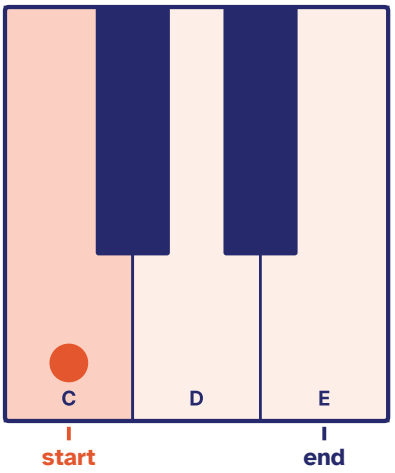
	MON TO SUN
Stool: forearms level with the keys	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Body: front half of the stool, feet flat	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Shoulders: lifted, then dropped	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Hands: round, knuckles up	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Breathe out, then play	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 2

The keyboard

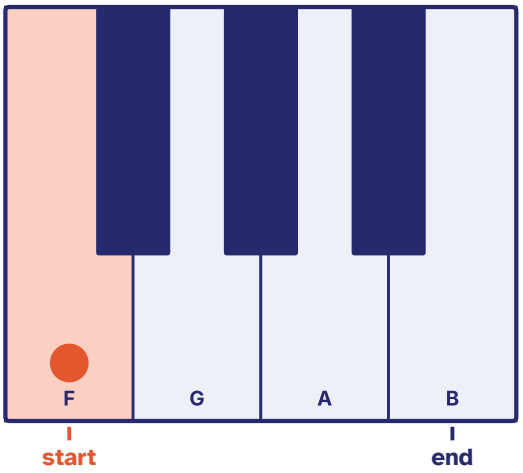
Handbook pp. 22–26 · listen in the app: Room 2

2 black keys: C D E



on the piano E and F touch

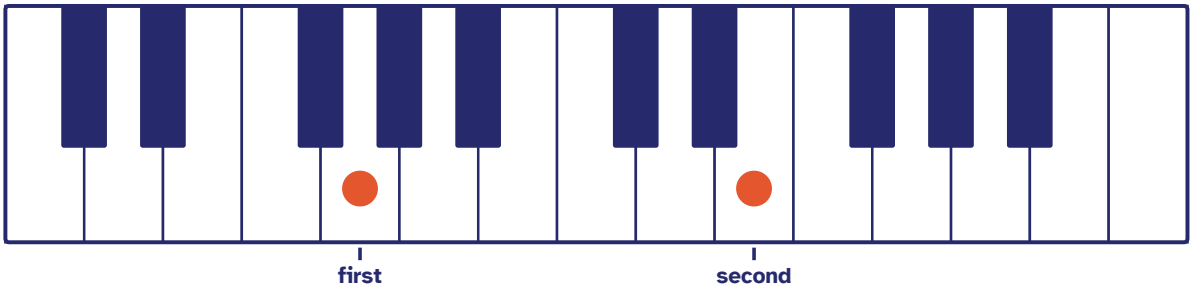
3 black keys: F G A B



Pulled apart: each family has a first key (start) and a last key (end)

EXAMPLE 1

Higher or lower?



1. **Find the two red keys.**
2. **Which one is further right?**
3. **Right means higher:** play both and listen.

The second note is **higher**: it is to the right. Left is always lower, right always higher.

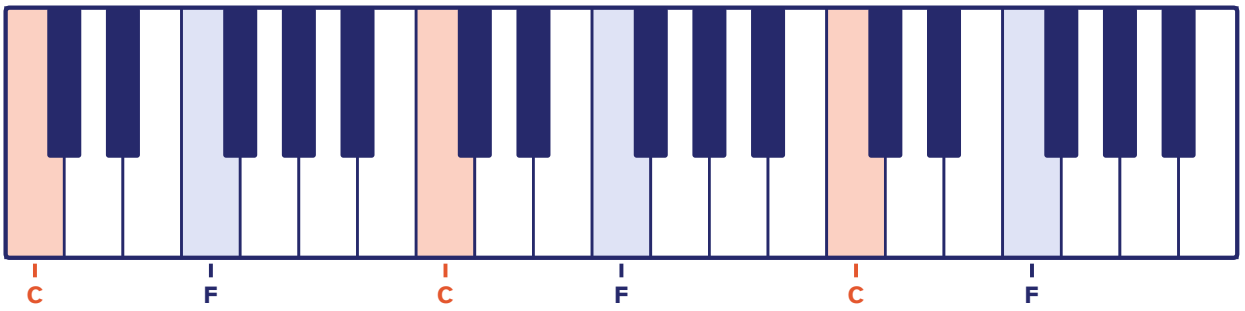
THE SECRET

Two black keys: start on C. Three black keys: start on F. Then walk on.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 2 · CONTINUED

THE RULE

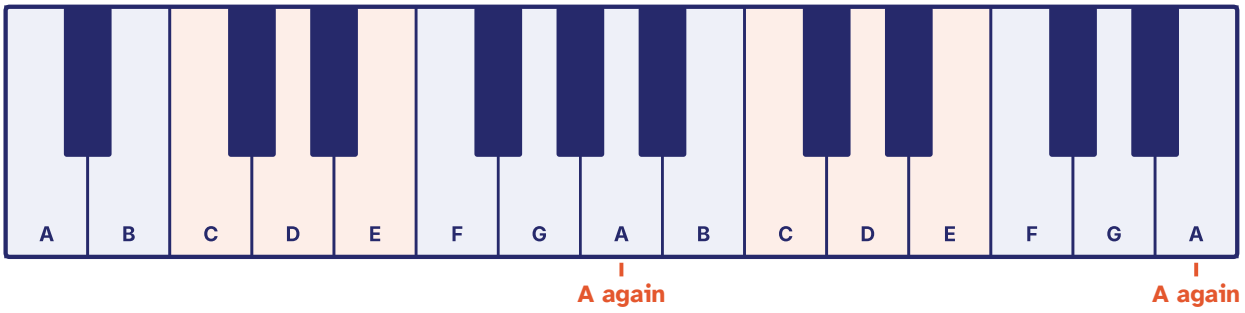
Find the group, then its first key. **Looking for D or E? Find two black keys and start on C. Looking for G, A or B? Find three black keys and start on F. You never have to count from far away.**



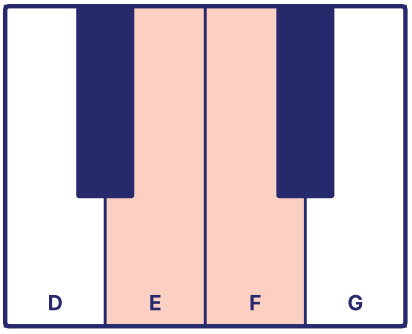
The pattern repeats all the way along: every two starts on C, every three on F

Seven letters, round and round

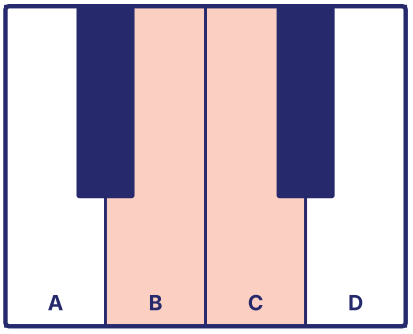
The white keys use only seven letters: **A B C D E F G**. There is no H. After G the next key is **A** again, and the seven letters go round and round, like the days of the week, all the way up the keyboard. **C D E** always sit round the two black keys, **F G A B** round the three. **E–F** and **B–C** have no black key between.



A B C D E F G, A B C D E F G, A …: after G, back to A



E–F: no black key between



B–C: no black key between

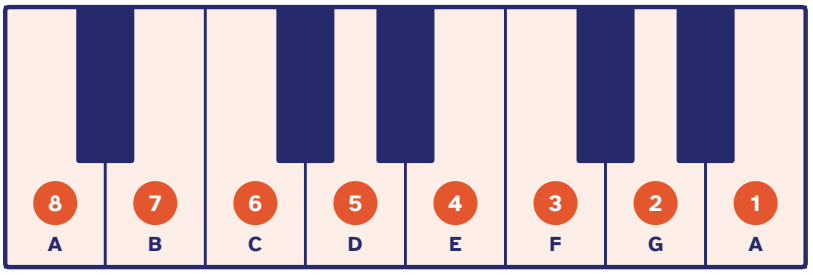
The only two pairs of white keys that touch: E–F and B–C

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 2 · CONTINUED

Going down: say it backwards

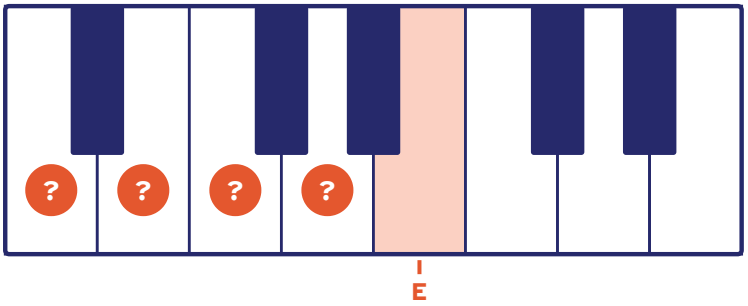
Walking **left**, down the keyboard, the letters run **backwards**: G F E D C B A, then G again. Practise saying them backwards until it is as quick as forwards: reading music that goes down depends on it.

← walk left: A G F E D C B A



EXAMPLE 2

Walk down from E

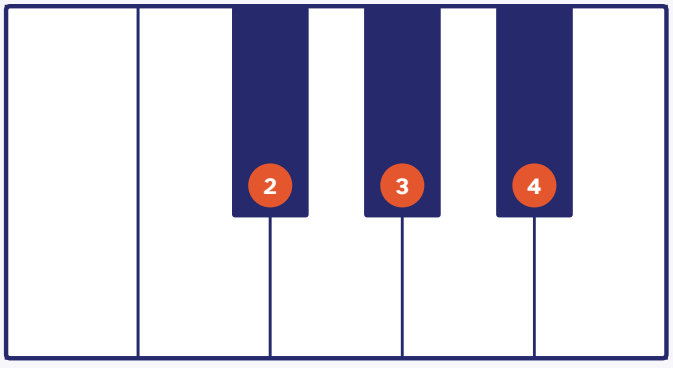


1. **Start on E**, between the two black keys.
2. **Step left** one white key at a time: name each one.
3. **Fill the gaps** out loud too: G _ E _ C.

E **D C B A**: backwards. And G **F** E **D** C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Hot Cross Buns, on three black keys



Right hand, fingers **2 3 4** on the three black keys (thumb is 1, little finger 5). Play from the top: **4 3 2**, 4 3 2, then quickly, twice as fast, **2 2 2 2, 3 3 3 3**, and 4 3 2 to finish. A whole tune, and not one white key.

Try it. Find another group of three, higher up, and play it again there.

THINK OF IT The black keys are bumps you can feel in the dark. Close your eyes and slide your hand along: two bumps, and the key to their left is C; three bumps, and the key to their left is F.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 2 · CONTINUED

Practise

1 Twos and threes ★☆☆

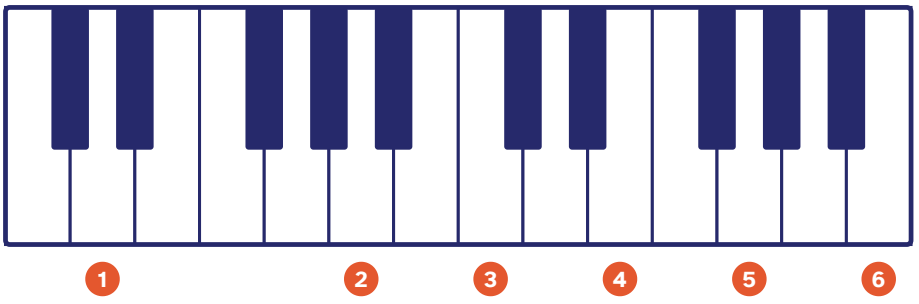
Circle every group of two black keys and every group of three. How many of each?



groups of two ☐ groups of three ☐

2 Name the keys ★☆☆

Find the group, then its first key, then walk on. Write the letter name of each numbered key. The first is done.



1 D 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐

3 Round and round ★☆☆

Seven letters, A to G, then A again. Write the next three letters: going up on the left, going down on the right. The first is done.

GOING UP	GOING DOWN
E F G **A B C**	C B A **G F E**
F G A	B A G
A B C	D C B

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 3

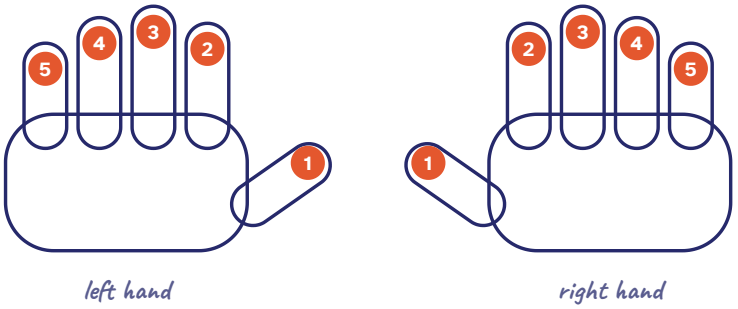
Fingering

Handbook pp. 163–164 · listen in the app: Room 3
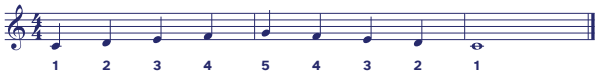
Each finger has a number, the same in both hands: the thumb is 1, the little finger 5. Good fingering is planned, not guessed: choose it once, write it in, and use it every time.

THE SECRET
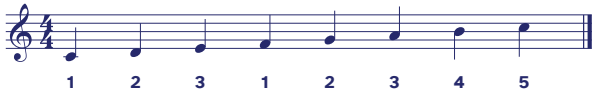
Thumbs are 1 in both hands. Choose a fingering once, write it in, keep it.
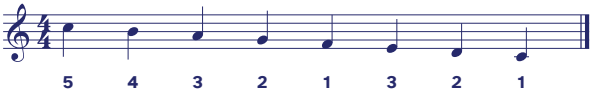


Thumbs are 1 in both hands



Thumb on C, one finger on each key up to G: five notes without moving the hand. Many first pieces stay in one position.



Up the scale: 1 2 3, thumb under to F, then 1 2 3 4 5.
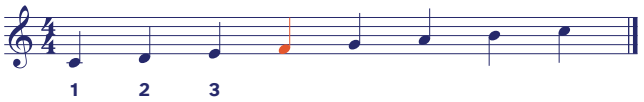


Down: 5 4 3 2 1, then 3 crosses over the thumb.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Play C D E F G with each hand, saying the finger numbers: right 1 2 3 4 5 up, left 5 4 3 2 1 up. Then both hands together.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Which finger plays the F?



?

1. **C D E** are 1 2 3.
2. **The F:** finger 4, or the thumb tucked under?
3. **Then** how do you reach the top C?

The **thumb** passes under to F; then 2 3 4 5 reach the top C.

EXAMPLE 2

Which finger plays G?

Right hand, thumb on C ?

1. **Thumb on C** is 1.
2. **Count up** one finger per key: D, E, F, G.
3. **So G** is…?

Finger **5**: C D E F G is 1 2 3 4 5.

GAME
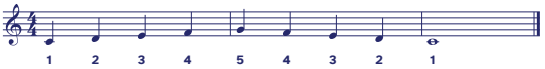
Name the finger

1	2
thumb	index
3	4
middle	little

Give the finger number.

Answer: 1 one · 2 two · 3 three · 4 five.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Five fingers, five keys.

Right hand on C D E F G. Play up and down, saying the finger numbers aloud. Then the left hand: 5 4 3 2 1 from C up.

TRAP

- × Changing fingering every time you play: choose one, write it in, keep it.
- × Landing heavily on the thumb as it passes under: let it glide.

Practise

2 C major, right hand

★★☆

Write the fingering going up. The first three are done.

	C	D	E	F	G	A	B	C
finger	1	2	3					

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 3 · CONTINUED

1 Five-finger position ★☆☆

Right-hand thumb on C, left-hand little finger on C: write the finger for each note. The first is done.

	C	D	E	F	G
right hand	1				
left hand					

3 Play it ★☆☆

Play C D E F G up and down with each hand, saying the finger numbers. Tick a circle each day.

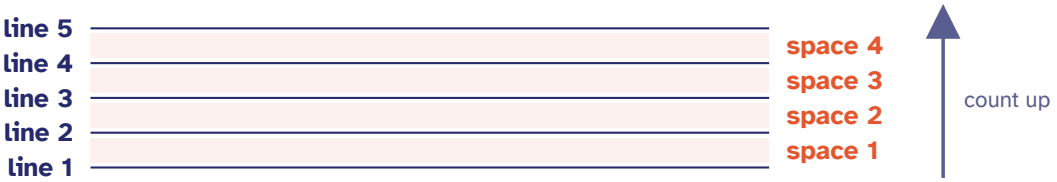
LEVEL 0 · ROOM 4

The staff and the clefs

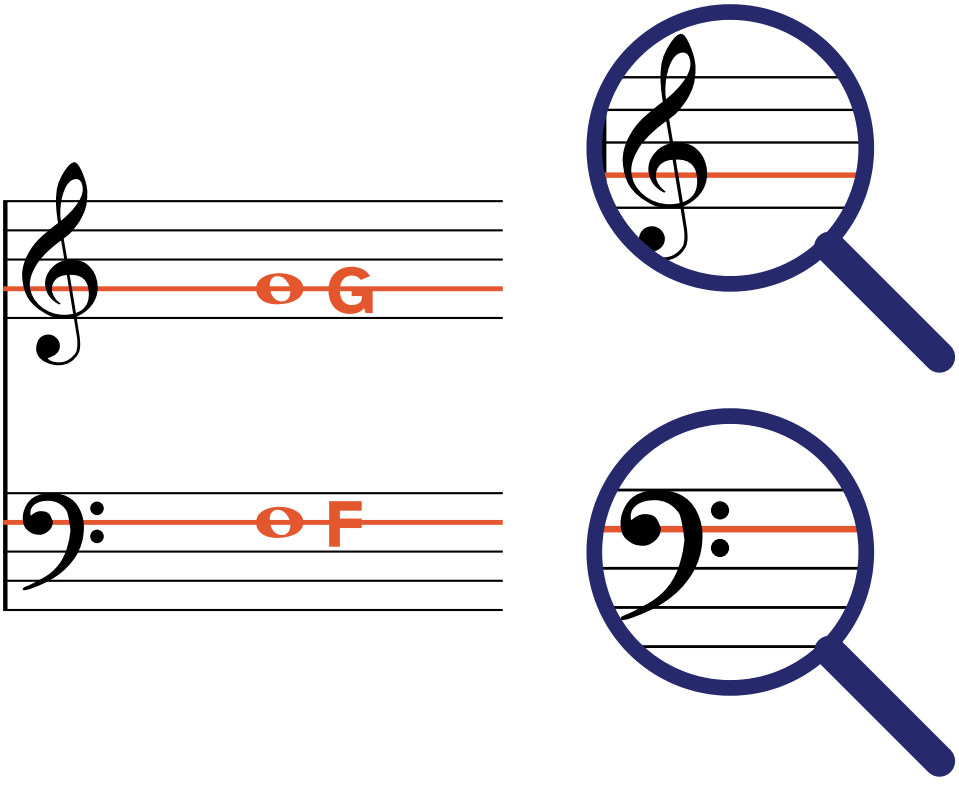
Handbook pp. 27–28 · listen in the app: Room 4

Music is written on a **staff**: five lines and four spaces, counted from the **bottom**. Higher on the staff means higher on the keyboard. The **clef** at the start is the key to the code: it names one line, and every other note follows from it.

Five lines, four spaces



Always count from the **bottom**: line 1 is the lowest line, space 1 the lowest space.



Treble clef = G clef
curls round line 2: G

Bass clef = F clef
its dots hug line 4: F

The treble clef is the G clef: it curls round G · the bass clef is the F clef: its dots hug F

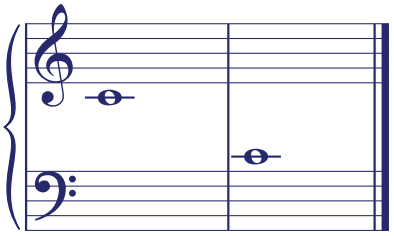
THE SECRET

The treble clef curls round G; the bass clef's two dots hug F.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 4 · CONTINUED

The grand staff

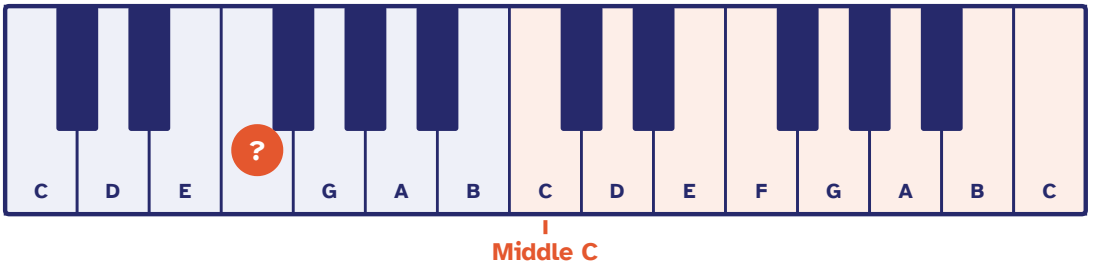
Two staves joined by a brace: the **treble** staff on top, usually for the right hand, and the **bass** staff below, usually for the left. **Middle C** sits between them on its own short line, in either staff.



Middle C in the treble staff (left) and in the bass staff (right): the same key.

EXAMPLE

Which staff is this key written on?
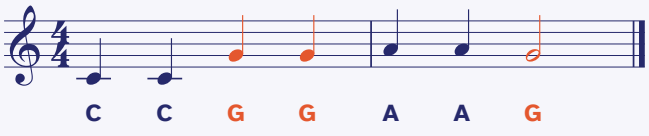


1. **Find Middle C.**
2. **Is the ? to its left or right?** Left is lower: the blue half.
3. **Low keys go on the bass staff**, high keys on the treble staff.

The **?** is below Middle C, so it is written on the **bass staff**, usually for the left hand.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



The treble clef curls round **line 2: G**, the very note Twinkle leaps up to. Read the round head, not the stem: the stem never changes the note.

Try it. Point to the G line, then play C C G G A A G.

THINK OF IT A clef is a pair of glasses: the same lines, read through a different pair.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 4 · CONTINUED

Practise

1 The clefs ★☆☆

Write the name of each clef and the note it marks.

CLEF	NAME	IT MARKS THE LINE FOR
		
		

2 Line or space? ★☆☆

Circle line or space, then write its number (counted from the bottom). The first is done.

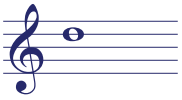


line · space
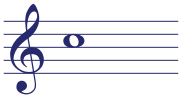
1



line · space



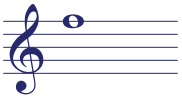
line · space



line · space



line · space



line · space

3 Treble or bass? ★☆☆

Which staff would each note usually be written on? The first is done.

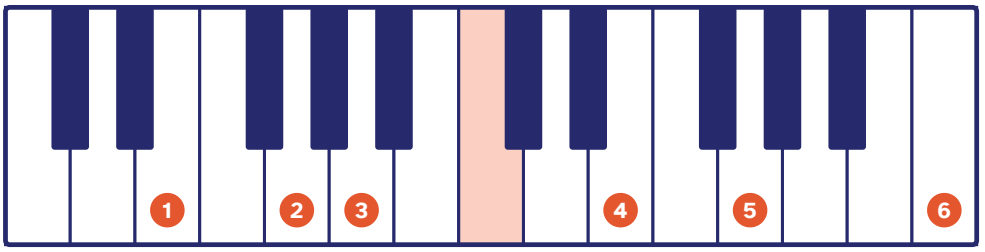
the E above Middle C	**treble** · **bass**
Bass C	**treble** · **bass**
High C	**treble** · **bass**
the lowest key on the piano	**treble** · **bass**
Treble C	**treble** · **bass**

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 4 · CONTINUED

4 Which staff?

★☆☆

Middle C is marked. Is each numbered key written on the treble staff or the bass staff?



Middle C

1	treble · bass	**2**	treble · bass	**3**	treble · bass
4	treble · bass	**5**	treble · bass	**6**	treble · bass

5 The grand staff

★☆☆

Complete each sentence.

Piano music joins two staves with a _____ .

The _____ staff is on top, usually for the _____ hand.

The _____ staff is below, usually for the _____ hand.

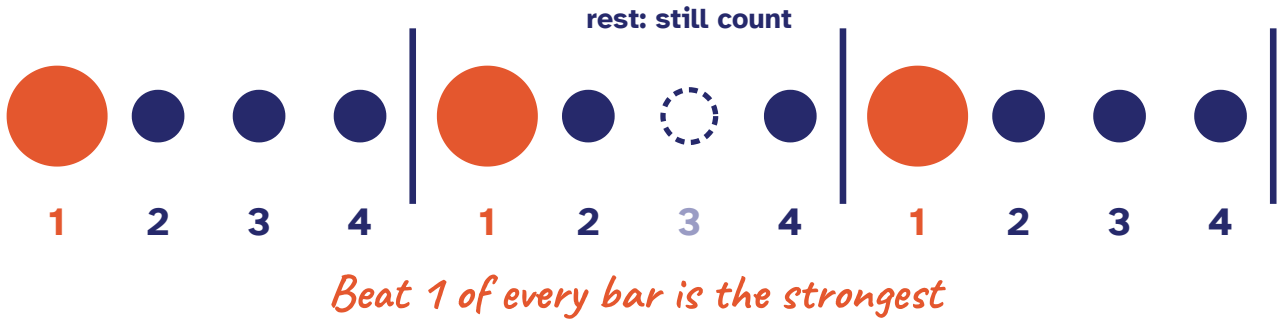
Between them, on a short line of its own, sits _____ .

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 5

Pulse, tempo and the bar

Handbook pp. 50–52 · listen in the app: Room 5

Put your hand on your heart: that steady beat is a **pulse**, and almost every piece has one. Its speed is the **tempo**. Beats travel in groups called **bars**, and beat 1 is the strongest.



Beat 1 of every bar is the strongest

THE SECRET

The beat never stops, not even in a rest. Feel it before you play.

EXAMPLE 1

Feel the beat before you play



1. **Read the mark:** ♩ = 96, 96 crotchet beats a minute.
2. **Listen first:** set the metronome and let one full bar go by, counting “1 2 3” in your head.
3. **Step in** on the next beat 1, the way you step onto a moving escalator.

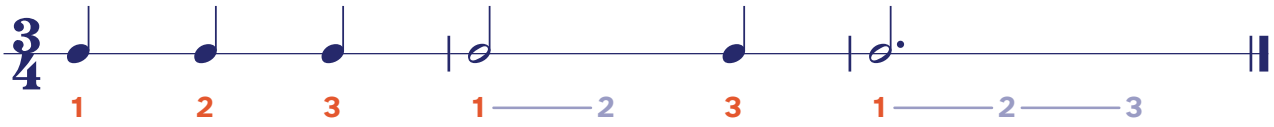
The first note lands **on the beat**, not a guess.

Bars and bar lines

SIGN	NAME	MEANING
	bar line	divides the music into bars
	double bar line	marks the end of a section, or a change of time signature or tempo
	final bar line	marks the end of the piece
	repeat signs	play the passage between them again; if there is no start sign, go back to the beginning

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 5 · CONTINUED

Counting



Three bars of 3/4 (the sign at the start: three beats in each bar, p. 59). Every beat is counted, even inside a long note: the red number is where you play, the grey numbers are the beats you hold.

Count aloud at one speed, a little louder on beat 1. With a metronome, start slower than you think and speed up only when the passage is steady.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
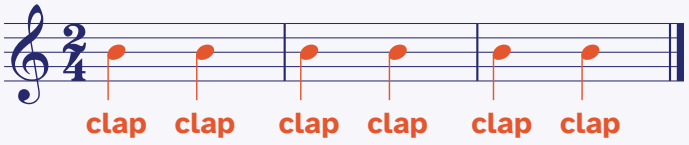


Hand on your heart. Tap the beat.

Say “1 2 3 4” with your taps, 1 a little louder. Keep going for ten seconds without slowing down.

YOU KNOW THIS

Radetzky March (Johann Strauss I)



At the New Year concert the audience claps along on **every beat**. That steady clap is the pulse; the orchestra’s tune moves freely over it.

Try it. Put on any march and clap only the beat, not the tune.

THINK OF IT The beat is the stage and the notes are the actors: the stage is there before anyone walks on. Step in as you would onto an escalator: watch it move for a bar, then join in.

Practise

1 Count it ★★☆

Write a count in every box: the beat you play, then the beats you hold. The first bar is done.

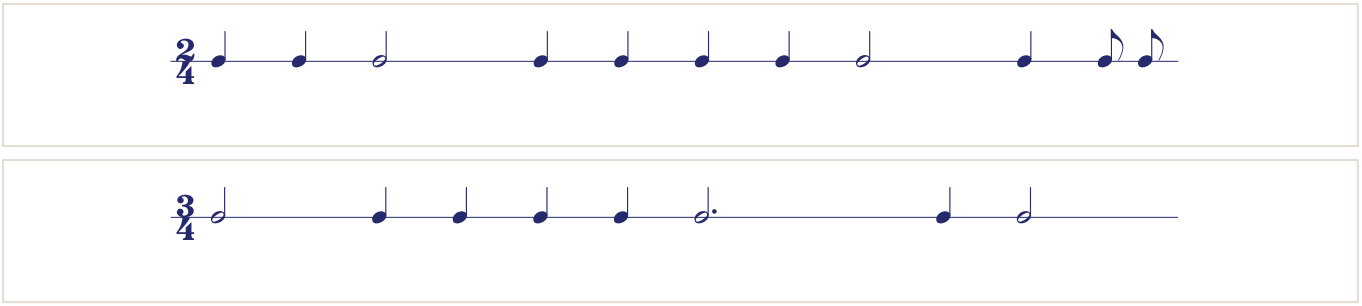


LEVEL 0 · ROOM 5 · CONTINUED

2 Add the bar lines

★★☆

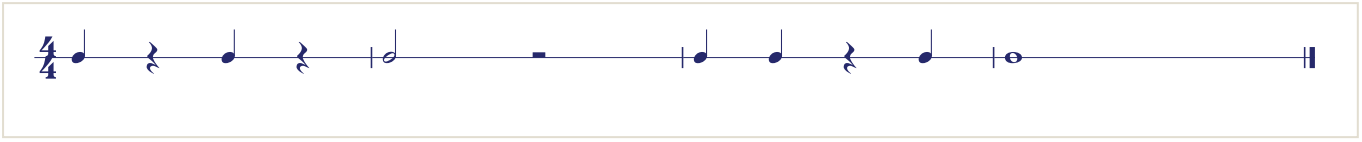
Draw a bar line after every full bar and a final bar line at the end.



3 Clap and count

★☆☆

Set a metronome to ♩ = **60**. Clap on the notes, open your hands on the rests, count aloud. Tick a circle each time it is steady.



LEVEL 0 · ROOM 6

Notes: the crotchet

Handbook pp. 53–55 · listen in the app: Room 6

4 crotchets 

Practise

1 How many beats? ★☆☆

Write the number of beats under each one. The first is done.



2 Play and count ★★☆

Say the counts out loud and play: a crotchet is play, a rest is shh. Write 1 2 3 4 under the bar.



3 Draw it ★★☆

Draw four crotchets, then two crotchet rests (a little lightning bolt).

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 7

Notes: the minim

Handbook pp. 53–55 · listen in the app: Room 7

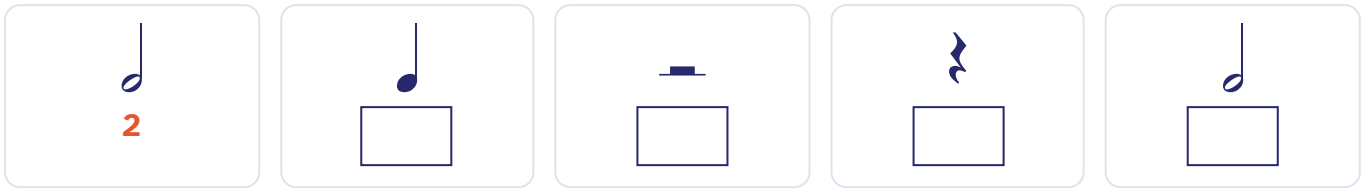
2 minims 

4 crotchets 

Practise

1 One beat or two? ★☆☆

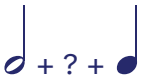
Write 1 or 2 under each. The first is done.



2 Fill the bar ★★☆

Four beats in each bar. Write the missing note: crotchet or minim. The first is done.

 minim





3 The hat ★★☆

Draw a minim rest: a block sitting on the middle line, like a hat. Then draw two minims.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 8

Notes: three beats

Handbook pp. 53–55 · listen in the app: Room 8



2 beats

2 + 1 = 3 beats

The dot adds half

Practise

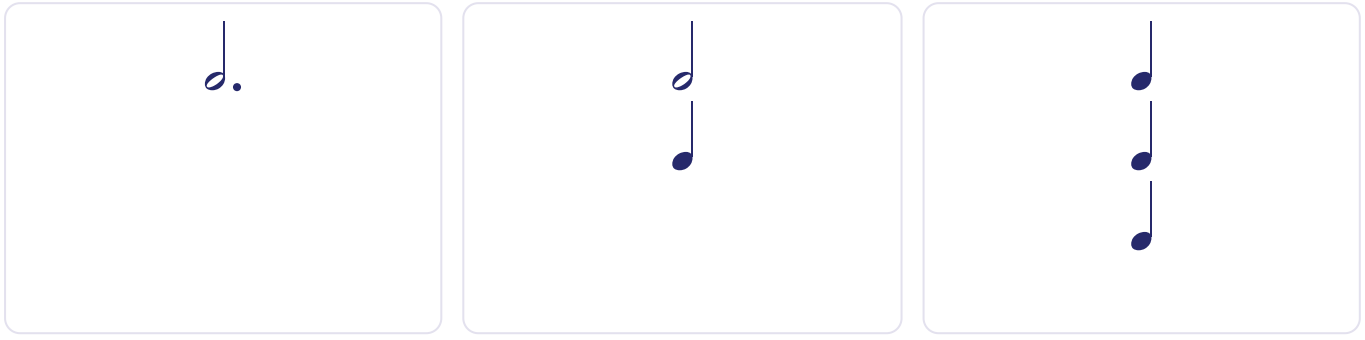
1 How many beats? ★☆☆

Write the number of beats. The first is done.



2 Waltz time ★★☆

Each bar has three beats. Count 1 2 3 and play. Which note fills the whole bar?



3 Add the dot ★★☆

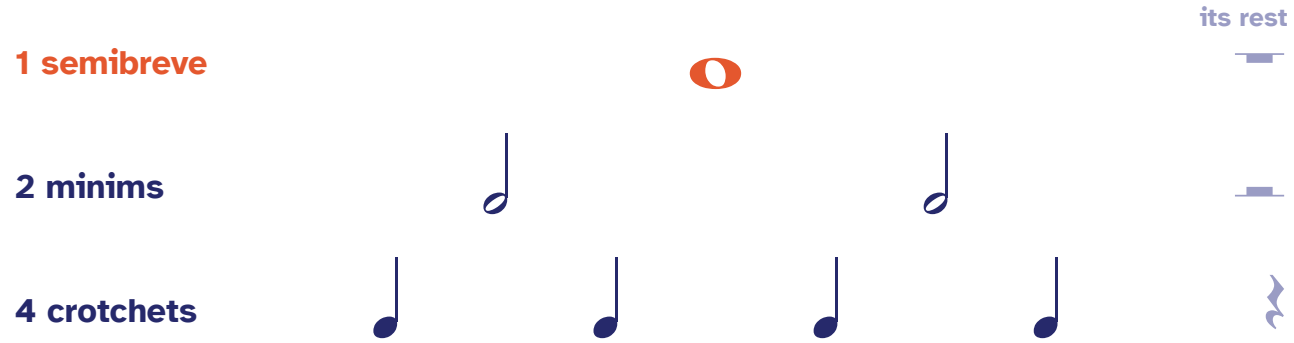
Make each minim last three beats: draw the dot after it.



LEVEL 0 · ROOM 9

Notes: the semibreve
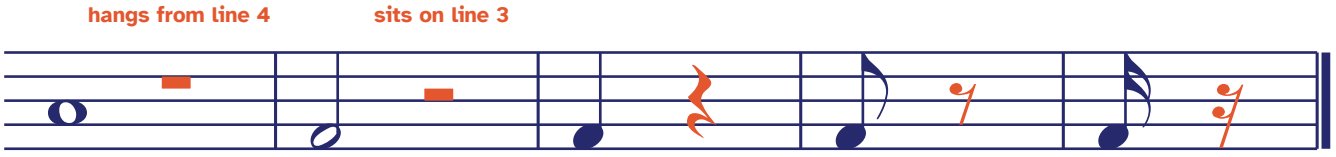
Handbook pp. 53–55 · listen in the app: Room 9



Each note splits into two of the next

THE SECRET

Each note is half the one above it, and every note has a rest twin.



semibreve	minim	crotchet	quaver	semiquaver
note and rest: 4 beats	note and rest: 2 beats	note and rest: 1 beat	note and rest: ½ beat	note and rest: ¼ beat

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 9 · CONTINUED

Why whole, half and quarter?

Think of each beat as a pizza. A bar of 4/4 is four pizzas. The note that fills a whole bar of 4/4 is the **whole note**; the others are a half, a quarter, an eighth and a sixteenth of it. Two quavers beamed together fill one pizza. A rest is the same share left empty: shaded with lines.

semibreve	whole note	4 pizzas · 4 beats	
semibreve rest	silence	4 beats, or a whole bar	
minim	half note	2 pizzas · 2 beats	
minim rest	silence	2 empty pizzas · 2 beats	
crotchet	quarter note	1 pizza · 1 beat	
crotchet rest	silence	1 empty pizza · 1 beat	
quaver	eighth note	half a pizza · ½ beat	
quaver rest	silence	half an empty pizza · ½ beat	
semiquaver	sixteenth note	a quarter of a pizza · ¼ beat	
semiquaver rest	silence	a quarter of an empty pizza · ¼ beat	

EXAMPLE 1

How long is each sound, and each silence?
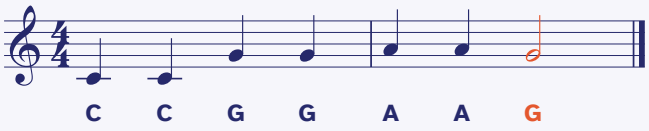


1. **Name each shape** in the bar.
2. **How many beats** does each one last?
3. **Add them up,** rests included. What is the total?

Minim 2, crotchet 1, crotchet rest 1: every bar adds up to **4 beats**, silences included.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



Six **crotchets**, then a **minim** at the end of the line: one beat, one beat … and two beats to breathe.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 9 · CONTINUED

Practise

1 Name, beats and rest ★☆☆

Fill in the table. The first row is done.

NOTE	NAME	BEATS	ITS REST
	semibreve	4	
			
			
			–

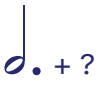
2 Coat or hat? ★☆☆

The semibreve rest hangs like a coat; the minim rest sits like a hat. Write coat or hat.

coat			

3 Four beats ★★☆

Each bar must add up to four beats. Write the missing note.

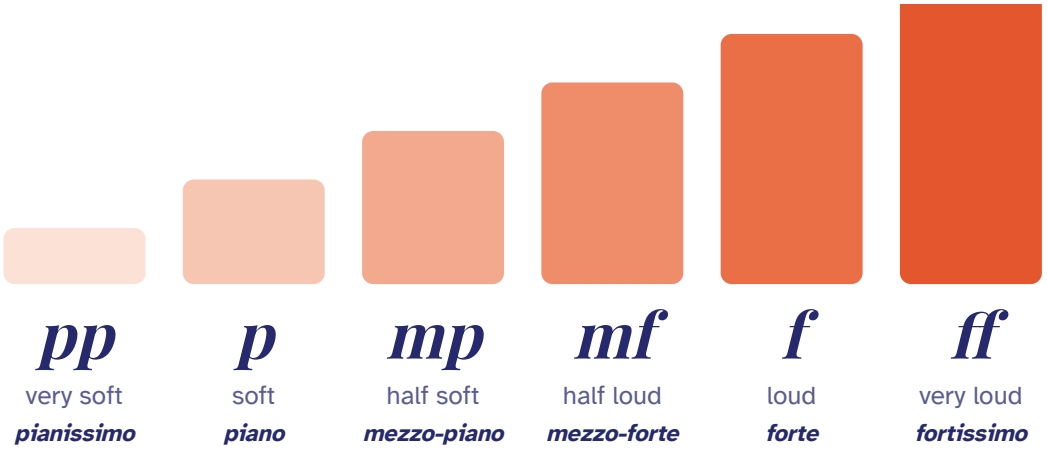
 + ?	crotchet
 + ?	
? (one note)	

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 10

Loud and soft

Handbook pp. 76–78 · listen in the app: Room 10

A voice can whisper, chat or shout. Music does the same, and small Italian words tell you which: the **dynamics**. They sit under the notes, shortened to one or two letters.



Six steps from a whisper to a shout

THE RULE

A sign lasts until the next one: *p* stays soft until a new sign arrives.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
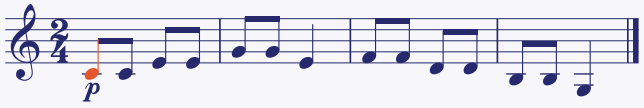
pp* → *ff

One note, six ways.

Play Middle C *pp*, then *p*, *mp*, *mf*, *f*, *ff*: six different steps, using the weight of your arm. Then come back down.

YOU KNOW THIS

Haydn's "Surprise" Symphony



The tune tiptoes along softly, *p*, then comes again even softer. Just as everyone relaxes, the whole orchestra crashes in with one **ff** chord: the surprise that gave the symphony its name.

Try it. Hum it very softly, then clap once, as loud as you can.

TRAP

- × Playing everything *mf*: each sign is a different step.
- × Speeding up in a crescendo: louder is not faster.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 10 · CONTINUED

Practise

1 Say it ★☆☆

Write the Italian name and what it means. The first row is done.

SIGN	NAME	MEANS
p	piano	soft
mf		
ff		
mp		
pp		
f		

2 Play it ★☆☆

Play Middle C six times: pp, p, mp, mf, f, ff. Six different steps? Tick a circle each day.